490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 20 OF 26

The Kingdom of God

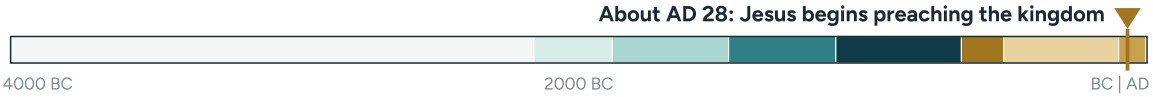
Mark 1–2; Matthew 5–7; 13



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October 18, 2026

YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 20



Introduction: The First Thing Jesus Said

When Jesus began his public ministry, around AD 27 to 29, Mark sums up his whole message in one sentence: "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel" (Mark 1:15). The kingdom of God was the theme Jesus talked about more than any other. Many of his best-known stories are about it. He taught his followers to pray for it. He said his miracles were signs of it.

For people who had walked through the whole Old Testament story, those words were electric. God had promised David a King whose throne would last forever (Lesson 14). Daniel had seen a kingdom that would never be destroyed (Lesson 17). After four hundred years with no new prophet, a man from Nazareth was standing up and saying: it is here. The King has come.

But the kingdom Jesus announced was not what anyone expected. This lesson looks at what he meant, who gets in, and the upside-down life he called his followers to, especially in his most famous sermon, the Sermon on the Mount (Matthew 5–7).

The Word: Kingdom

> **Colossians 1:13–14** *"He has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son, in whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins."*

βασιλεία *(basileia, "kingdom")*

God's reign: his royal rule, and the people who gladly live under it

Not mainly a place	+	Already here	+	Not yet complete
a reign		*Matt. 12:28*		*Matt. 6:10*
Where God is King and his will is done.		Begun in Jesus, entered now by faith.		We still pray, "Your kingdom come."

Payoff: Matthew usually says "kingdom of heaven," the other Gospels say "kingdom of God." They mean the same thing. Many Jews of Jesus' day said "heaven" out of reverence, to avoid overusing God's name. The kingdom is God's saving rule, no party's platform and no nation's border, breaking into a rebel world through his Son, and one day filling the whole earth.

Part One: The King Arrives

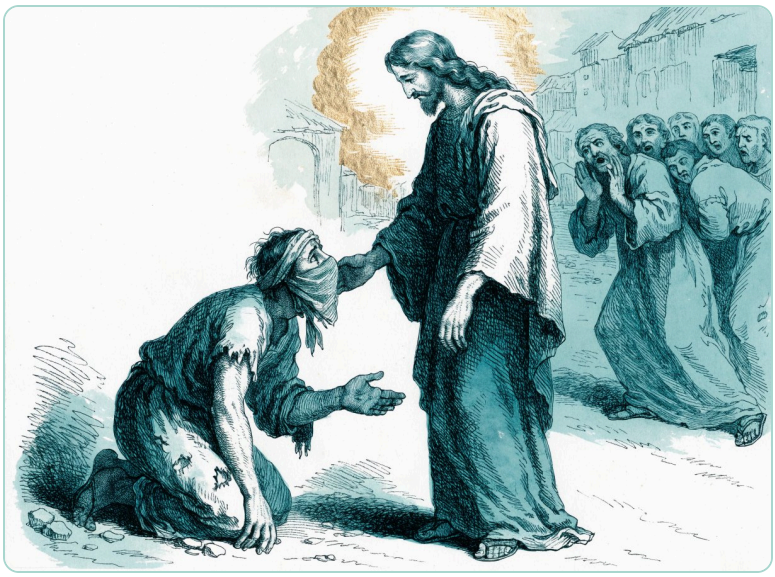
Jesus did not just talk about the kingdom. He showed it. In his hometown synagogue in Nazareth, he read from Isaiah: “The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty those who are oppressed.” Then he sat down and said, “Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing” (Luke 4:18, 21).

And he did it. He called ordinary fishermen to follow him: “Follow me, and I will make you become fishers of men.” And “immediately they left their nets and followed him” (Mark 1:17–18). He healed the sick, cast out demons, and fed the hungry. He said, “if it is by the Spirit of God that I cast out demons, then the kingdom of God has come upon you” (Matt. 12:28). Every miracle was a preview of what God’s rule will one day do in the new creation: no more sickness, no more evil, no more death.



“Follow me, and I will make you become fishers of men” (Mark 1:17).

Watch who he spent time with. A man with leprosy, a skin disease that made a person unclean and an outcast, knelt in front of Jesus and said, “If you will, you can make me clean.” Under the law, touching him made you unclean. But Jesus was “moved with pity.” “He stretched out his hand and touched him and said to him, ‘I will; be clean’” (Mark 1:40–41). The uncleanness did not pass to Jesus. The cleanness passed to the man.



"Moved with pity, he stretched out his hand and touched him" (Mark 1:41).

He ate dinner with tax collectors and notorious sinners, and the religious leaders were scandalized. Jesus answered, "Those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick. I came not to call the righteous, but sinners" (Mark 2:17). The kingdom was open to exactly the people everyone assumed were shut out.

Part Two: The Upside-Down Kingdom

Matthew records Jesus' longest sermon, preached on a mountainside in Galilee (Matt. 5:1), traditionally placed on the hills above the Sea of Galilee. We call it the Sermon on the Mount. It begins with eight blessings, called the Beatitudes:

> **Matthew 5:3–6** *"Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. Blessed are those who mourn, for they shall be comforted. Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth. Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they shall be satisfied."*

Every value of the world is turned upside down. The world says the strong, the confident, and the self-made are blessed. Jesus says the kingdom belongs to the "poor in spirit," people who know they have nothing to bring God. It belongs to those who mourn over sin, to the meek, to the hungry for righteousness, to the merciful, the pure in heart, the peacemakers, and the persecuted (5:3–10). The way in is down.

The Upside-Down Kingdom (Matthew 5:3–10)

THE WORLD SAYS BLESSED ARE…	JESUS SAYS BLESSED ARE…	
the self-confident	**the poor in spirit**	*5:3*
the unbothered	**those who mourn**	*5:4*
the strong and assertive	**the meek**	*5:5*
those who have it all	**the hungry for righteousness**	*5:6*
those who get even	**the merciful**	*5:7*
the impressive on the outside	**the pure in heart**	*5:8*
those who win every fight	**the peacemakers**	*5:9*
the popular	**the persecuted for righteousness' sake**	*5:10*

"Whoever would be great among you must be your servant" (Mark 10:43).

Jesus kept turning things over. "Whoever would be great among you must be your servant, and whoever would be first among you must be slave of all" (Mark 10:43–44). When parents brought their children to him and the disciples shooed them away, Jesus was indignant: "Let the children come to me; do not hinder them, for to such belongs the kingdom of God. Truly, I say to you, whoever does not receive the kingdom of God like a child shall not enter it" (10:14–15).

He taught his followers to be salt and light in the world (Matt. 5:13–16). He told them to love their enemies and pray for those who persecute them (5:44). He warned them not to store up treasure on earth, "For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also" (6:21). He told them not to be anxious, but to "seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you" (6:33). And he taught them to pray, "Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven" (6:10).

Part Three: A Righteousness You Cannot Reach

The Sermon on the Mount is beautiful. It is also terrifying, if you read it honestly. Jesus said he came not to abolish the law but to fulfill it, and then he said, "unless your righteousness exceeds that of the scribes and Pharisees, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven" (5:17, 20). The Pharisees were the most careful law-keepers in Israel.

Then he went deeper than any rule-keeper ever had. You have heard, "You shall not murder." But Jesus said that "everyone who is angry with his brother will be liable to judgment" (5:21–22). You have heard, "You shall not commit adultery." But "everyone who looks at a woman with lustful intent has already committed adultery with her in his heart" (5:27–28). And he summed it up: "You therefore must be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect" (5:48).

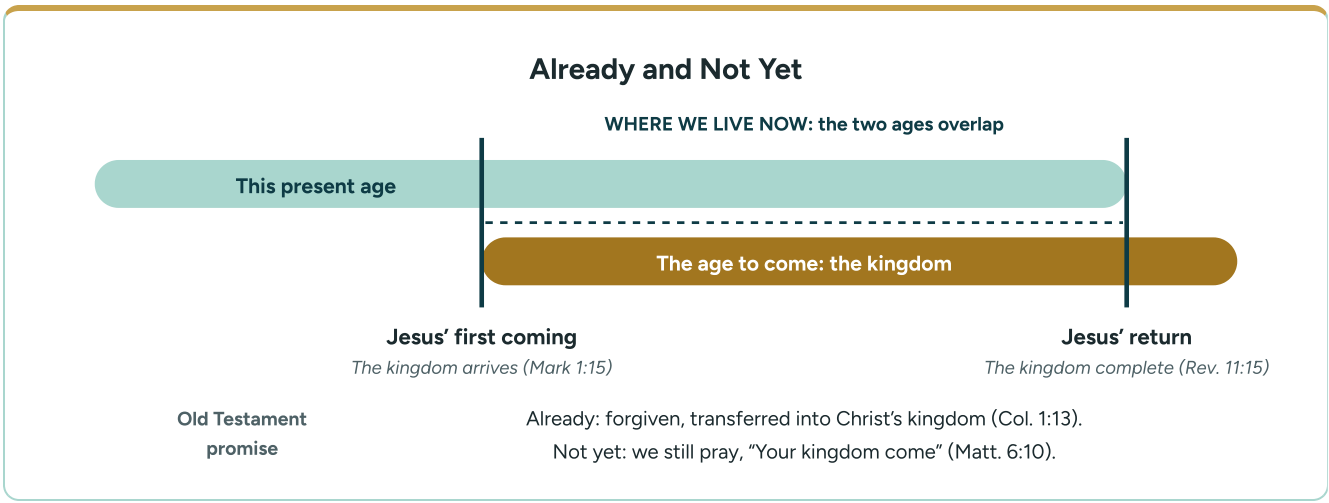
Who can do that? No one. That is the first thing the Sermon wants us to see. Like the law at Sinai (Lesson 9), the Sermon works first as a mirror. It shows that we cannot enter God's kingdom on our own record. The only righteousness that exceeds the Pharisees' is a righteousness God gives. Paul longed to "be found in him, not having a righteousness of my own that comes from the law, but that which comes through faith in Christ" (Phil. 3:9). Jesus lived the Sermon on the Mount perfectly, every word, and he would die to pay for every line we have broken. Both his perfect record and his payment are credited to everyone who trusts him. And God does more than credit us: he gives a new heart that begins to love what the Sermon commands. That is how the poor in spirit inherit the kingdom.

And then, for those who belong to him, the Sermon becomes a guide. It is no ladder into the kingdom. It is a portrait of life inside it. Jesus ended with a story about two builders: one built his house on the rock and one on sand. When the storm came, only one stood. "Everyone then who hears these words of mine and does them will be like a wise man who built his house on the rock" (7:24). The crowds were astonished, "for he was teaching them as one who had authority" (7:29).

Part Four: Already and Not Yet

Jesus' disciples, like many in Israel, expected the Messiah to drive out the Romans and set up a political kingdom immediately. Jesus surprised them. His kingdom would start small and hidden, and grow. "The kingdom of heaven is like a grain of mustard seed that a man took and sowed in his field. It is the smallest of all seeds, but when it has grown it is larger than all the garden plants and becomes a tree…" (Matt. 13:31–32). It works like a little leaven, or yeast, that slowly spreads through a whole batch of dough (13:33).

So the kingdom is **already** here. It came with Jesus, and anyone who trusts him is "transferred… to the kingdom of his beloved Son" right now (Col. 1:13). But it is **not yet** here in full. Sickness, injustice, and death still walk the earth. That is why Christians still pray, "Your kingdom come." One day it will come completely, when Jesus returns, and the cry will go up, "The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ, and he shall reign forever and ever" (Rev. 11:15).



How do you get in? Jesus told a religious leader named Nicodemus, "unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God" (John 3:3). It takes a new birth by the Spirit, a work only God can do. And the newborn heart answers the way Jesus called everyone to answer: "repent and believe in the gospel" (Mark 1:15). Turn from going your own way, and trust the King.

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE The King sits on a hillside with fishermen, touches lepers, and eats with sinners. "The kingdom of God is in the midst of you," Jesus said (Luke 17:21), because the King himself was standing there.

THE LAMB This King did not come to be served. "For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (Mark 10:45). The kingdom would be won not with a sword but with a cross. That is Lesson 21.

The Turn: Treasure Worth Everything

Jesus told two very short stories about what it is like to find the kingdom. "The kingdom of heaven is like treasure hidden in a field, which a man found and covered up. Then in his joy he goes and sells all that he has and buys that field." And it is "like a merchant in search of fine pearls, who, on finding one pearl of great value, went and sold all that he had and bought it" (Matt. 13:44–46).

Notice the words "in his joy." Following Jesus costs everything. The fishermen left their nets. But no one in those stories feels like he is making a sacrifice. He has found something worth more than everything else he owns put together. The kingdom of God is the treasure.

Those parables measure what the kingdom is worth. They never set its price. The King paid that himself, at the cross. You cannot buy your way in with good works; the Sermon on the Mount shows that. But you can receive it as a gift, like a child. The poor in spirit are blessed, because theirs is the kingdom. Come with empty hands. Repent and believe the good news. And then live the rest of your life as a citizen of the kingdom that cannot be shaken (Heb. 12:28), praying every day, "Your kingdom come, your will be done."

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read the Sermon.** Read Matthew 5–7, one chapter a day for three days, then read it all at once.
2. **Pray the Lord's Prayer slowly.** Pray Matthew 6:9–13 each day, pausing on each line. When you pray "your kingdom come," name one heart, starting with your own, where you long to see Jesus obeyed as King.
3. **Be poor in spirit.** Begin each day by telling God honestly that you have nothing to bring him but your need.
4. **Move toward an outcast.** Like Jesus with the leper, go toward someone others avoid this week.

5 **Love an enemy.** Pray by name for someone who has hurt you (Matt. 5:44).

6 **Memorize Matthew 6:33.** “But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.”

Before Lesson 21: *Read Mark 14–15 and Isaiah 52:13–53:12. Lesson 21 follows the King to the cross, where the final Lamb was offered.*

For Discussion

1. Jesus’ first message was “the kingdom of God is at hand.” What do you think people expected the kingdom to look like? What did they get?
2. Jesus touched a leper and ate with sinners. Who are the people everyone avoids in your world? What would it look like to move toward them?
3. Read the Beatitudes (Matt. 5:3–10). Which one surprises you most? Which one do you most need?
4. Jesus said anger and lust break God’s law in the heart. How does the Sermon on the Mount work as a mirror for you?
5. If no one can reach the righteousness Jesus requires, how does anyone enter the kingdom?
6. Jesus told Nicodemus, “unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God” (John 3:3). Why does entering the kingdom take a new birth? Why isn’t a better effort enough?
7. The kingdom is “already” and “not yet.” Where do you see it already? Where are you still longing for it?
8. In Jesus’ parables, a man sells everything “in his joy.” What would it look like for you to treat the kingdom as treasure rather than burden?

Sources & For Further Study

- On βασιλεία and the kingdom of God: Herman Ridderbos, *The Coming of the Kingdom*; George Eldon Ladd, *The Gospel of the Kingdom* (on “already and not yet”).
- On the Sermon on the Mount: D. Martyn Lloyd-Jones, *Studies in the Sermon on the Mount*; Sinclair B. Ferguson, *The Sermon on the Mount*.
- For further reading: Westminster Larger Catechism 191 (on “Thy kingdom come”); Timothy Keller, *King’s Cross*.



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